

The Revolution Without Its Founders: Miami's Semiquincentennial and the New Grammar of Civic Belonging

I. Introduction

On June 15, 2026, a Boeing 737 designated the "Freedom Plane" will touch down in Miami carrying the 1823 Stone engraving of the Declaration of Independence, the 1783 Treaty of Paris, and oaths of allegiance signed by George Washington, Alexander Hamilton, and Aaron Burr (HistoryMiami Museum). HistoryMiami Museum, one of only eight venues nationwide selected by the National Archives for the tour, will display these documents through July 5 with free admission (HistoryMiami Museum). The occasion is the American Semiquincentennial, and the setting is a city that did not exist when any of these documents were signed.

This is the puzzle at the center of Miami's 250th. The colony of East Florida, far from joining the rebellion, served as a refuge for Crown loyalists at the time of the Revolution. Miami itself was not incorporated until 1896, more than a century after independence, and the county that will host these founding documents is majority-immigrant. It's shaped less by any inherited Anglo-American founding narrative than by the successive arrivals of Cuban, Haitian, and Venezuelan communities, each carrying its own political memory (Portes and Stepick). A city with no organic claim on the Revolution is trying to commemorate it.

This essay argues that the puzzle dissolves once we recognize that Miami's immigrant communities relate to Revolutionary memory through a fundamentally different rhetorical mode than earlier generations of immigrants did. Where nineteenth and early twentieth century arrivals commemorated the Revolution as a pathway to assimilation, anchoring their claims in Revolutionary-era founders, Miami's immigrant groups commemorate only when a specific political motive demands it, and the resulting commemoration centers ideals over founders. The differences among Miami's Cuban, Haitian, and Venezuelan communities in how they engage (or decline to engage) with the Revolution reveal that its political memory is produced by present conditions rather than inherited from historical record. With that, the city's immigrant commemorations reveal a broader transformation in how excluded communities claim the American project, one in which the founders have become optional but the ideals have not.

The paper begins with the inherited rhetorical tradition of earlier immigrant commemoration, then turns to Miami's 2026 programming and classifies it into four distinct commemorative modes. It examines the Cuban-American production of Revolutionary memory in detail, reads the other immigrant communities against that case, and closes with a broader observation about how American civic claims are made nowadays.

II. The Inherited Rhetorical Tradition: Earlier Immigrant Commemoration

The rhetorical methods (specific communication techniques for conveying a particular message) that Miami immigrants are departing from is old and well documented. From the mid-nineteenth century onward, European immigrant communities in the United States claimed belonging by proving personal or community lineage at the founding. Polish Americans erected monuments to Kościuszko and Pulaski, two volunteers who had crossed the Atlantic to serve in the Continental Army (Warsaw Institute). Between 1904 and 1927, they erected at least six Kościuszko statues in cities with large Polish populations, each funded by the community and each making the same implicit argument: a Pole helped establish the republic, therefore Poles can claim it (Polish Museum of America). Irish Americans similarly claimed Commodore John Barry, whom they promoted as the father of the American Navy. The Friendly Sons of St. Patrick installed a Barry statue at Independence Square in Philadelphia in 1907, and September 13 is still observed as Commodore Barry Day with an annual commemorative mass at Old St. Mary's Church, where Barry is buried (Museum of the American Revolution). German Americans claimed Baron von Steuben, the Prussian drillmaster who professionalized Washington's army at Valley Forge.

In each case, the historical claim did not need to be grand, but it needed to exist, because the work being performed was not historical scholarship but rather a form of credentialing. Crucially, the monuments were not built and left alone. Communities placed them in their own civic spaces rather than at Revolutionary historical sites where the founders had fought, and they became focal points for recurring commemorative rituals tied to national anniversaries. Polish Americans activated their Kościuszko claims at the 1926 Sesquicentennial, sending 111 volumes of signed tributes invoking Kościuszko and Pulaski; at the 1976 Bicentennial, commissioning a new Kościuszko statue in Detroit explicitly "to honour America's Bicentennial"; and established Casimir Pulaski Day as an Illinois state holiday in 1977 ("A Polish Tribute"). Commemoration, in this mode, was a mechanism of

assimilation itself. It was how outsiders demonstrated that they had always, in some sense, been insiders, and the proof was renewed at every national anniversary.

The founder-anchored claim was not exclusive to immigrants. Every group excluded from the original republic's promise eventually reached for a Revolutionary figure to authorize its demands. Black abolitionists elevated Crispus Attucks, the man of African and Wampanoag descent who was the first person killed at the Boston Massacre in 1770 ("Crispus Attucks"). Beginning in the 1850s, William Cooper Nell and other Black leaders in Boston petitioned the Massachusetts legislature for a monument in his honor, inaugurated March 5 as "Crispus Attucks Day," and built a commemorative tradition that used Attucks to show that Black Americans had been present, and had bled, at the Republic's very inception (Native Northeast Portal).

The women's suffrage movement worked the same rhetorical ground. At the 1876 Centennial celebration in Philadelphia, the National Woman Suffrage Association was denied a place in the official program. Susan B. Anthony, undeterred, crossed the outdoor stage at Independence Square immediately after the reading of the Declaration of Independence, thrust a "Declaration of Rights of the Women of the United States" into the hands of Senator Thomas Ferry, and then walked to a nearby platform to read the full document to the crowd that gathered around her (National Park Service). The Attucks monument and the Anthony protest illustrate the same structural logic that immigrant communities later adopted: anchor your claim in a founding-era figure or founding-era document, and use the anniversary commemoration as the stage on which to press it.

By the Bicentennial of 1976, the relationship between excluded communities and founding mythology had shifted again. European ethnic groups, now several generations deep, had accumulated enough demographic and institutional weight to expand the American origin story, rather than *merely* seeking inclusion within the existing narrative. Ellis Island shows how immigration had become a founding narrative in its own right, one in which the act of coming to America carried equal symbolic weight as the act of declaring independence. On top of that, the federal government structurally facilitated this shift. The American Revolution Bicentennial Administration created a Bicentennial Ethnic Racial Council with dedicated workshops designed to embed immigrant and ethnic participation in the 1976 commemoration (Inclusive Historian's Handbook). For the first time, the national anniversary was not merely tolerating ethnic presence but actively subsidizing it. The Bicentennial was

the moment when the founder-anchored tradition ("our ancestors were there") merged with a broader immigrant-arrival tradition, and the federal state endorsed the merger.

Miami's own 1976 experience sits awkwardly inside this story. The city was one of four municipalities designated by the Nixon administration as part of a federal program that helped each city produce a signature commemorative project (Piket). Miami's contribution was New World Center, a bayfront park carved from the old Port of Miami and dedicated on July 4, 1976 (Piket). The park generated no local excitement and was widely judged a failure (Piket). It was a commemoration imposed from above, without any organic connection to the local population's actual civic life. Little Havana, the neighborhood west of downtown that had become the social and political center of Cuban exile life in the United States, had the institutional weight to participate. Organisations like the Latin Chamber of Commerce were well established, and the community was the most politically organized in the city. But Cuban-American Bicentennial programming was notably absent. The exile community's political energies were directed toward Havana, not toward the founders or the founding documents.

What Miami's immigrants inherited, then, was a two-stage tradition. In the first stage, running roughly from the mid-nineteenth century through the early twentieth, immigrant communities (and other excluded groups) anchored their claims to specific Revolutionary-era founders and martyrs: Pulaski for Poles, von Steuben for Germans, Barry for the Irish, Attucks for Black Americans. A revolutionary presence was the entry to the national story. In the second stage, consolidated by the 1976 Bicentennial and its federal ethnic-inclusion programming, the founding itself was redefined as an immigrant story (e.g. Ellis Island becoming a national jewel on par with Independence Hall). Both stages assumed that claiming the Revolution required grounding in the historical record, whether through a specific founder or through the broader narrative of immigrant arrival. What Miami's 2026 commemorations reveal is a third mode, one that neither anchors in founders nor redefines the founding. Miami is treating the Revolution's ideals as propositions available for whatever political purpose the present demands. The next section classifies what that looks like in practice.

III. A Taxonomy of the Commemorations Themselves

Miami-Dade County's 2026 programming is not a single commemoration but several simultaneous ones, each claiming the Revolution for a different purpose. The county's "We Are America" Advisory Committee coordinates a schedule that culminates in a July 4, 2026

celebration at Tropical Park, but the programming it oversees has no unified interpretive center (Miami-Dade County). What it has instead are institutions pursuing four distinct commemorative modes with varying representations. Miami is not producing a consensus anniversary. Rather, it's producing a set of competing claims on the founding, and the competition reveals what happens when Revolutionary memory is constructed from the present backward in a city where no single community can claim the past.

The most prominent form of commemoration in Miami is the "scripturalization" of the founding documents. HistoryMiami Museum was selected as one of only eight venues nationwide for the National Archives' "Freedom Plane National Tour: Documents That Forged a Nation," which brings original founding-era artifacts to the museum from June 20 through July 5, 2026 (HistoryMiami Museum). The documents travel by Boeing 737, and the Miami run includes the 1823 Stone engraving of the Declaration of Independence, the Articles of Association, the Treaty of Paris, oaths of allegiance signed by Washington, Hamilton, and Burr, and a Senate markup of the Bill of Rights (HistoryMiami Museum).

Natalia Crujeiras, CEO of HistoryMiami, has framed the exhibit in language that elevates it from a simple artifact display to a civic ritual: "These documents belong to all Americans. Presenting them in Miami, a global city shaped by democratic ideals and extraordinary diversity, creates a powerful space for reflection on our nation's origins and its ongoing promise" (Crujeiras, qtd. in WSVN). The companion programming reinforces this sentiment. HistoryMiami's "America 250: Voices of the Future" oratorical contest invites high-school students countywide to "reflect on the enduring ideals of America's founding documents," and the winning essay will be accessioned into the museum's permanent collection, a small gesture that treats a student's words as continuous with the founding texts themselves (HistoryMiami Museum).

This is the kind of reverence Pauline Maier warned against: the Declaration was not born sacred, but was gradually transformed into an unquestionable holy document through acts of re-sacralization exactly like this one (Maier). Each generation's commemoration performs another such act, and the Freedom Plane tour is the 2026 version: founding documents flown between American cities like relics on pilgrimage, displayed under glass for free so that citizens can stand before them and feel the weight of origins.

Another local form of commemoration uses the Revolution to impose a patriotic emphasis. The Phillip and Patricia Frost Museum of Science is running "America250: Celebrating

American Innovation," a poster exhibition profiling 250 American scientists, innovators, engineers, and change-makers across fields from ocean exploration to human health (Frost Museum of Science). The museum is also partnering with SciStarter on a national citizen-science initiative aiming toward "2.5 million Acts of Science" (Frost Museum of Science). The exhibit does not touch the Revolution. It does not mention 1776, the Declaration, or any founding-era figure. Instead, it uses the 250th anniversary as an occasion to celebrate American ingenuity as a free-standing ideal, detached from any specific Revolutionary memory.

The Revolution here is pretext, not subject. The Frost Museum's programming treats "America" as a container for present-day civic projects that have no organic connection to the colonial rebellion. The 250th anniversary supplies a number and a branding opportunity, but nothing more. What makes this significant is that no visitor to the Frost Museum will feel like the exhibit is off-topic. "Celebrating American innovation" seems like a perfectly natural way to honor the nation's birthday. That naturalness is itself evidence of how far commemorations have traveled from the founding era. The Revolution has become so thoroughly absorbed into a generic American identity that it can be invoked without being mentioned.

A third set of institutions treats the Revolution not as a completed event to be venerated or a brand to be borrowed, but as a continuing struggle in which the Cuban chapter is still being incomplete. The Brigade 2506 Museum reopened in April 2026 as an 11,000-square-foot facility in Little Havana, timed to the 65th anniversary of the Bay of Pigs invasion (Salomon). The museum houses seven interactive stations and over 800 digitized photographs (Salomon). Veteran Manuel Portuondo, who enlisted at eighteen, stated that "the museum's purpose is not only to cement the legacy of what thousands of men did on that day, but also, from a historic perspective, to tell the new generations that freedom has a price" (Salomon). Representative Mario Díaz-Balart, speaking at the April 2026 anniversary, called the Brigade veterans "courageous Cuban patriots who risked everything in the fight for freedom against a brutal dictatorship" (CubaHeadlines). The words used; patriots, tyranny, freedom, sacrifice; are Revolutionary in register, but the revolution being invoked is not 1776. It is the ongoing Cuban struggle, encased in an American founding vocabulary that makes the two indistinguishable.

Another example of this mode is Miami Dade College's Freedom Tower, the former Cuban Refugee Emergency Center that processed roughly 400,000 Cuban exiles between 1962 and

1974 (Miami Dade College). Crujeiras (HistoryMiami CEO) has described the Tower as "that symbol of America as a welcoming place where you as a refugee flee communism, political persecution, you could find a path forward" (Crujeiras, qtd. in CBS News). The Tower's current exhibitions focus on Cuban artists and the exile experience rather than on explicit 250th content, an absence that is revealing. Even more, Books & Books in Coral Gables rounds out this mode with "Songs for America" on April 28, 2026, a poetry-and-music event featuring Richard Blanco (the Cuban-American poet who read at Obama's 2013 inauguration) alongside other Miami poets (Books & Books). The lineup is intensely Cuban-American, and the framing is commemorative, but the content is treating the 250th as an occasion for artistic expression rooted in exile experience. In contrast, the "scripturalization," this mode brings Miami into the founding, rather than the other way around.

Finally, a set of institutions uses the 250th not to sacralize the founding or to extend it, but to interrogate it. The Pérez Art Museum Miami's "This Is America: Selections from PAMM's Collection," opening May 28, 2026, assembles works by artists around themes the museum describes as "a multiplicity of perspectives on American history and identity," foregrounding "women, immigrants, Black artists, Indigenous artists, and artists of color" (Pérez Art Museum Miami). PAMM's exhibit does not celebrate America. Instead, it asks what America is through artists whose relationships to the national story are defined by exclusion, displacement, and adaptation. The sacralization and interrogation (this mode) operate inside the same 250th frame, but they perform opposite moves. One treats the founding as settled and sacred, while the other treats it as open and contested.

Hattem's central insight in *The Memory of '76*, that Americans have never agreed on what the Revolution meant and that Revolutionary memory divides as often as it unites (Hattem), is visible across all four modes. The "scripturalizing" mode treats the Revolution as a sacred past. The propositional mode treats it as a set of ideals available for any current project. The exile mode treats it as a structurally ongoing struggle. The contested mode treats it as a site for interrogating American identity. None of these modes is doing what earlier immigrant commemoration did (claiming ancestral presence at a completed founding), and all of them are doing something that depends on the founding being a living political reality rather than a closed historical event.

However, the modes are not equally elaborated in Miami. The exile mode has the deepest institutional roots, and the next section explains how that infrastructure was built.

IV. Cuban-American Exile Politics and Revolutionary Memory

On January 1, 1959, Fidel Castro's 26th of July Movement overthrew President Fulgencio Batista after a six-year armed conflict (PBS). Within months, the new government began nationalizing private property, aligning with the Soviet Union, and suppressing political opposition (PBS). What followed was a mass exodus that unfolded in successive waves, each drawing from a different stratum of Cuban society. The first wave, from 1959 to 1962 (often called the "Golden Exile"), brought roughly 248,000 Cubans to the United States, predominantly upper and middle-class professionals, business owners, and landowners whose property had been confiscated (Migration Policy Institute). Most settled in Miami, and most expected the exile to be temporary (Migration Policy Institute). The failed Bay of Pigs invasion in April 1961, in which a CIA-trained force of approximately 1,400 Cuban exiles (Brigade 2506) attempted to overthrow Castro and was defeated in three days, deepened both the community's anti-Castro resolve and its sense of betrayal by the Kennedy administration (PBS). A second wave followed through the "Freedom Flights" negotiated between Washington and Havana from 1965 to 1973, bringing roughly 260,000 more Cubans, now drawn increasingly from the working and lower-middle classes (Migration Policy Institute). The 1980 Mariel boatlift, a third wave, brought 125,000 people during a single chaotic summer (Migration Policy Institute). A fourth wave, the balsero crisis of 1994, saw thousands attempt the crossing on makeshift rafts after the Soviet Union's collapse devastated Cuba's economy (Migration Policy Institute). The community that built the rhetorical infrastructure this section describes was shaped primarily by the first two waves: educated, politically conservative, overwhelmingly white, deeply Catholic, and defined by the conviction that they were exiles from tyranny rather than immigrants seeking opportunity (García).

The rhetorical tradition that this community inherited and amplified begins with the nineteenth-century Cuban independence movement, which had deep roots in the United States and drew deliberately on American Revolutionary vocabulary from the start. José Martí, the poet and organizer who the exile community revere as the apostle of Cuban independence, lived in the United States from 1880 to 1895, writing extensively on Washington and Lincoln (Fountain). The Cuban flag itself was conceived in Manhattan in 1849 in red, white, and blue, visibly resembling the American flag in a context shaped by Narciso López's annexationist politics (Couceiro Rodríguez). Cuban independence politics

was, from its inception, entangled with American Revolutionary imagery, and the post-1959 exile community carried that inheritance to Miami.

The post-1959 exile community institutionalized this tradition at scale. The Freedom Tower served as the Cuban Refugee Emergency Center from 1962 to 1974 (Miami Dade College). Brigade 2506 was organized in 1961 (PBS). The Cuban American National Foundation, modeled on AIPAC, was founded in 1981 by Jorge Mas Canosa and framed its mission around "freedom, democracy and human rights" (Grenier). A Cuban-American congressional delegation carried exile rhetoric into the legislative record. The community understood itself "as exiles as opposed to immigrants," as María Cristina García documents in *Havana USA*, a self-conception that naturally grafts onto Revolutionary memory because exiles, like 1776 patriots, understand themselves as political actors in flight from tyranny rather than as economic migrants seeking opportunity (García).

Marco Rubio's 2015 presidential announcement at the Freedom Tower is the most fully articulated public statement of this rhetoric: "I chose to make this announcement at the Freedom Tower because it is a symbol of our nation's identity as the land of opportunity" ("Full Text"). He then merged the exile arrival with the entire arc of American founding: "a collection of immigrants and exiles, former slaves and refugees, became one people, and together built the freest and most prosperous nation ever" ("Full Text"). The sentence places Cuban exiles alongside former slaves and immigrants in a single founding act, as if there was no difference between the Revolution and the exile. Ileana Ros-Lehtinen's December 2018 farewell speech on the House floor performed the same fusion in a more personal register: "America opened its arms to my family and to me as we fled the Communist Castro regime. When we arrived in Miami, it was in one of the last commercial flights out of Cuba... We are a country that says you can be successful no matter where you started" ("Ileana Ros-Lehtinen"). Mario Díaz-Balart, speaking at the 65th Bay of Pigs anniversary in April 2026, called the Brigade veterans "courageous Cuban patriots who risked everything in the fight for freedom against a brutal dictatorship" (CubaHeadlines). The lexicon across all three figures is consistent and unmistakably Revolutionary: patriots, tyranny, freedom, sacrifice, the land of opportunity. But the revolution being invoked through these words is not the one that ended in 1783. It is the one that, in the exile community's self-understanding, has not ended at all.

They contend that Cuba is an unfinished revolutionary moment, and that the tyranny the exile community opposes is the same tyranny of 1776. As Manisha Sinha views the Civil War and Reconstruction era as a continuation of the Revolution (or a Second American Revolution), so does the Cuban-American community extend the Cuban exile as part of the American Revolution (Sinha).

V. The Other Communities: Haitian and Venezuelan

The Cuban case demonstrates that commemoration follows from political motive and institutional infrastructure, not from the strength of any historical claim to the founding. Miami's other major immigrant communities offer variations on this finding, and the variations are instructive because they do not track the distribution of historical claims. The community with the strongest direct connection to the American Revolution has done the least with it. The community with the most dramatic contemporary political rupture has invoked American ideals without invoking American founders. The pattern across both cases confirms the thesis: Revolutionary memory in Miami is produced by present conditions, not inherited from historical record.

The Haitian case reveals that historical claims alone do not produce commemoration. Approximately 500 free men of color from Saint-Domingue, organized as the Chasseurs Volontaires de Saint-Domingue, fought at the Siege of Savannah in 1779, providing the cover that enabled the Franco-American retreat (Face2Face Africa). This is a direct, documented military contribution to the American Revolution, stronger than anything the Polish or Irish communities had when they built their monument campaigns in the nineteenth century.

The Haitian American Historical Society, headquartered in Miami, has invested significantly in this claim. The society spent years raising roughly \$500,000 to build the Haitian Monument in Franklin Square, Savannah, a bronze ensemble depicting the Chasseurs-Volontaires (Go South Savannah). Daniel Fils-Aimé, the society's chairman, framed the monument in language that echoes the founder-anchored tradition exactly: "This is a testimony to tell people we Haitians didn't come from the boat. We were here in 1779 to help America win independence. That recognition is overdue" (Associated Press). This is genuine founder-anchored work by a post-1965 Miami immigrant organization, and it complicates any simple claim that later-arriving communities do not make such moves. But, two distinctions matter. First, the monument sits in Savannah, 500 miles from the community that funded it, placed at the historical site rather than in Miami's own civic space. Compare

this to the Kościuszko statues in Chicago and Milwaukee, the Barry statue in Philadelphia, or the Freedom Tower and Brigade 2506 Museum in Little Havana. Earlier immigrant communities and Cuban exiles planted their founder-claims in their local neighborhoods, turning them into permanent fixtures of local civic identity. The Haitian monument is practically closer to historical preservation than to civic self-assertion. Second, and more critically, the 250th has arrived and the claim sits dormant. No visible Little Haiti programming activates the Chasseurs-Volontaires heritage for the Semiquincentennial. When Polish Americans built Kościuszko statues, they reactivated them at every national anniversary, from the 1926 Sesquicentennial to the 1976 Bicentennial (“A Polish Tribute”). The Haitian community constructed the claim but has not performed it at the commemorative moment when performance would matter most, because the political conditions that would make activation useful are not present.

If the Haitian case shows that a strong historical claim does not automatically produce commemoration, the Venezuelan case shows the inverse: a community can invoke Revolutionary ideals with extraordinary emotional intensity without reaching for any historical claim at all. On January 3, 2026, U.S. forces captured Nicolás Maduro in Caracas, ending 26 years of Chavista rule (Al Jazeera). Hundreds of Venezuelans poured into Doral (home to the largest Venezuelan-origin population of any U.S. city and nicknamed “Doralzuela”) and gathered outside El Arepazo restaurant, singing both the Venezuelan and American national anthems as the sun rose (WLRN). Nora Villamarin told WLRN she dreamed of taking her children to see a country they had never known (WLRN).

A historical claim was available. Francisco de Miranda, the Venezuelan revolutionary known as “El Precursor,” fought under Gálvez at the 1781 Siege of Pensacola and subsequently met Washington, Hamilton, Jefferson, Knox, Samuel Adams, and Thomas Paine (“Francisco de Miranda”). On top of that, Miranda kept an extensive record of his role and experience in the American revolution. Miranda's service is a usable past that could function for Venezuelans exactly as Kościuszko functions for Polish Americans. But, Venezuelan political rhetoric in Miami routes instead through Simón Bolívar, the early nineteenth-century general who liberated Venezuela, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, and Bolivia from Spanish rule. Bolívar occupies a position in Latin American political memory roughly analogous to Washington's in the United States. So much so that a Bolívar sculpture stands beside a Doral strip mall near El Arepazo, an assertion of which founding figure this community claims as its own.

The January 2026 celebrations produced chants of "¡Libertad!" and national anthems, not invocations of American founders (WLRN). "Libertad" operates as a free-standing ideal, detached from any specific founder, American or Venezuelan. The Venezuelan diaspora invokes liberty as a portable value rather than anchoring it in any founding-era biography.

The two cases together confirm what the Cuban case alone might leave ambiguous. The Haitian community has the strongest direct connection to the American Revolution of any immigrant group in Miami, a documented military contribution at Savannah that is more concrete than anything the Polish or Irish communities possessed when they built their nineteenth-century monument campaigns, and it has not deployed that connection for the 250th. The Venezuelan community has a moderate claim and routes around it. The pattern extends further. Miami's Colombian population, the second-largest of any U.S. metro area, has no Revolutionary-era claim and shows no sign of needing one. Even Miami's Nicaraguan exiles in Sweetwater, whose flight from Ortega's authoritarianism structurally parallels the Cuban experience, deploy contemporary human-rights language rather than Revolutionary-era vocabulary (Padgett; CBS News Miami). The Cuban case is elaborated not because Cuban Miami's relationship to the Revolution is inherently deeper, but because Cuban exile politics developed during a moment when Revolutionary vocabulary was still the available rhetorical grammar for exile claims. Later-arriving communities do not need the grammar, and so they do not build it.

VI. The Broader Shift

The pattern visible in Miami is not unique to Miami. The founder-anchored rhetoric that earlier immigrant communities used to claim the Revolution was not peculiar to immigrants. It was the dominant grammar of American civic protest for most of the nation's history, and its decline is a broader phenomenon that Miami's immigrant communities happen to illustrate.

Nineteenth-century movements for inclusion almost universally grounded their claims in founding-era figures and founding-era texts. The women's suffrage movement, as Section II described, modeled the 1848 Declaration of Sentiments on the Declaration of Independence and crashed the 1876 Centennial to present a "Declaration of Rights of the Women of the United States" that explicitly held the nation accountable to its own founding language (National Park Service). Black civic rhetoric operated in the same register. Frederick Douglass's 1852 "What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?" is the canonical example. It's a

speech that derives its entire moral force from holding the Declaration's promises against the reality of slavery, demanding that the nation either fulfill its founding propositions or confess them as lies. In both cases, the logic was identical to the immigrant monument campaigns: our people were there, therefore the Republic owes us what it promised. Claims to the founding were not optional for these movements, because in the mid-nineteenth century, the ideals alone carried no independent political force for excluded groups. Liberty and equality were not yet portable concepts that could be invoked without reference to the specific historical moments that had given them meaning. The founders had to be named, the documents had to be quoted, and the anniversaries had to be seized, because the ideals had no authority apart from the founders who had articulated them.

Over the twentieth century, this changed. The legal and political victories of the civil rights movement, the women's movement, and the broader expansion of democratic participation transformed what the founding ideals meant in American public life. By the post-1965 period, liberty and equality had acquired rhetorical influence detached from specific founder-anchored claims. Later-arriving movements generally did not need to do the founder-grounding work. For example, LGBTQ rights rhetoric invokes liberty and equal protection without invoking any founding figures. Another example is that contemporary immigration-rights movements invoke due process and human dignity without constructing monuments to Revolutionary-era figures. The ideals became portable without requiring the historical credentialing that earlier movements had treated as essential. The grammar broadened rather than was replaced, but the broadening is visible wherever new immigrant communities engage with American civic life.

Miami's immigrant communities map onto this broader arc. Cuban exile politics formed during the transitional moment when founder-anchored rhetoric was still the dominant mode, but the shift had begun. The Cuban move is therefore hybrid: it grafts onto founders and claims ideals structurally, spanning both rhetorical eras. This is why the Cuban case is elaborated in a way later communities' cases are not. The Haitian community's dormant Savannah claim and the Venezuelan community's free-standing "¡Libertad!" are not failures to do what the Cubans did. They are instances of communities arriving after the rhetorical environment had shifted, finding that the ideals were available without the founders attached.

VII. Conclusion

The puzzle that opened this paper dissolves once its terms are understood. Miami's 2026

programming is not a single commemorative project with a single author. It is the convergence of independent forces: a federal apparatus that selected Miami as a tour stop, museums and libraries pursuing their own institutional missions, and a Cuban exile rhetorical tradition that provides a detailed case study. What unifies the four modes is the broader shift away from the Revolution's historical details and towards its ideals. None of Miami's 2026 commemorations is doing what earlier immigrant communities did, anchoring their belonging in ancestral presence at a completed founding. All of them treat the Revolution's ideals as resources available for present purposes, whether that purpose is re-sacralization, scientific branding, exile politics, or artistic interrogation. The result is a semiquincentennial without any clear consensus.

But the absence of a unified narrative may be more revealing than any consensus could have been. What Miami's 2026 programming demonstrates is not merely that different communities use the Revolution differently, but that the Revolution's ideals have become available independently of the Revolution's history. Earlier excluded groups needed a Kościuszko or an Attucks, a figure who proved they had been present at the founding, because the ideals carried no force apart from the historical record that had produced them. That dependency has dissolved over the course of the twentieth century. The civil rights movement, the women's suffrage movement, and the broader expansion of democratic participation transformed liberty and equality into concepts that could be invoked without reference to the specific founding moments. Miami's immigrants claim liberty without claiming a founder, and in this they are arriving at the place Revolutionary rhetoric has been heading since the ideals stopped requiring the founders to authorize them.

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